Coyote on a Fence

By Bruce Graham

Bobby *– White Inmate on death row; late 20s, skinny, pale, damage to one of his eyes*
John *– White inmate on death row; mid 40s; writes obituaries for "The Death Row Advocate"*
Sam *– Reporter from the NY Times – 30's*
Shawna *– Prison guard, race doesn't matter.*

BOBBY: (Pg 44) *(singing as he bounces a ball, he appears almost childlike and when he doesn't know the words he uses "da, da")* "God rest ye Merry gentlemen, let nothing you da, da. Remember Christ our savior was born on Christmas day.

JOHN: (Pg 49) In seventy-two hours they are going to kill you.

BOBBY: And I will go to a better place. **(Pg 51)** That's in the Bible, John. *(returns to his ball bouncing, which he enjoys very much)* **(Pg 46)** Dashing through the snow, in a one horse open sleigh, o'r the fields we go, laughing all the way ha-ha-ha *(Bobby breaks into giggles)*

JOHN: (Pg 49) If I could get that on tape and show it to a jury, they'd never kill you. You're runnin' around like a happy puppy or something.

BOBBY: *(blank look; John has lost him, but he understood the word "puppy" and he begins to imitate one, taking the ball in his mouth and making puppy noises)* I'm a happy puppy!

INTRODUCTION

*Welcome to Death Row. * This year, as of November 1, 2024, 21 prisoners have been executed in 8 US states, with over 2,200 still awaiting execution. (update as needed) And while the number of death sentences per year have dropped dramatically since 1996, 27 States, the US Federal Government and the US Military still retain it as a sentencing option for heinous crimes. ** President-elect Trump, during his 2024 campaign for re-election, signaled his stance on capital punishment -- indicating he would make more people eligible including child rapists, migrants who kill US citizens and those convicted of drug and human trafficking. How do **you** feel? Is the death penalty warranted for these types of crimes; or are you against this form of punishment? The State vs Robert Alvin Reyburn provides the backdrop for this drama . . .*

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BOBBY: (Pg 27) (to the audience) God spoke ta me a lot. . . but that mornin' . . . I'm passin' a church - had an old pick-up Uncle Hew gimme - and I could hear 'em in there . . . singin' . . .

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Beautiful singin'.

SAM: (Pg 32) [His] mother was a transient. Did some prison time herself: prostitution, public drunkenness, assault.

BOBBY: (Pg 27) I pull over and just listen. And then God said, "Help them, Bobby. You gotta' help those people . . . show them the way home!"

SAM: (Pg 32) Drunk all through her pregnancy. Got beat up pretty bad when she was seven months along. Between the booze and the beating, they're pretty sure the fetus suffered a little . . . damage.

BOBBY: (Pg 28) So I went in..."Excuse me Reverend? I need to speak the word of God!"

SAM: (Pg 33) He never made it out of the seventh grade.

BOBBY: (Pg 28) Got real quiet...everybody starin' at me. But I didn't feel no hate. *(to the congregation)* "God has spoken to me! He wants you all to know it is immoral for whites and n**** ta live together."

BOBBY: (Pg 28) *(shocked)* They turned on me. Started clawin' at me like animals--you believe that? *I was tryin ta help them! (A deep breath).*

SAM: (Pg 35) Mother had him put in the juvenile detention center for running away. He was twelve – other kids were older. Whole dorm – first night. Got a little rough, shattered his hip.

BOBBY: (Pg 28) I got in my truck, drove down the road... *(Bobby laughs in God's voice, then speaks in awe)* It was God! *(in God's voice)* "They mock you, Bobby, they mock me! They must be cleansed!" I turned around and headed back. They're singin' again--real loud--so I pulled the truck right up to their door there. Parked it, got out my gas can, made a big ring. Let the circle be unbroken. *(beaming)* Sat under a tree and watched . . .

SAM: (Pg 33) Fire killed thirty-seven people. Fourteen of them kids. Sunday school in the basement. He didn't just confess, he made a proclamation. Took full responsibility.

JOHN: (Pg 33-34) The trial . . . There was no medical testimony. There was no psychological testimony. He's not competent enough to take responsibility. Bobby totally disassociates. He shouldn't be on the row!

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BOBBY: (Pg 20) Hey, I ever do my penguin for ya? Watch this *(he begins to waddle around like a penguin)* **(Pg 23)** *(begins to frantically look for something – he's suddenly in a panic)* Where's my towel? I need my towel!

JOHN: Here! Take mine if it'll shut you up! *(he shoves his towel into Bobby's cell)*

BOBBY: *(Bobby grabs it desperately and holds it tightly to his chest)* They done this before. They want my other eye. They got this one when I was sleepin' but they ain't gettin' the other one. *(whispering intently)* That's when they get ya – when you're sleepin'. They get bleach outta' the laundry and throw it in your face. Burns . . . Lord it burns. So I always gotta' sleep with a towel over me.

SHAWNA: (Pg 36) They're all bullshitters. *(mocking)* I'm poor, I'm black, daddy beat me, momma didn't love me.

BOBBY: (Pg 30) Seal! *(tries to balance a ball on his nose, slaps his hands and makes seal sounds)*

SAM: (Pg 35) *(quiet but intense)* I am against the death penalty *(pause)* I think people like Bobby are evil. I know that's probably . . . simplifying things a little too much. But *(shrugs)* I keep picturing thirty-seven people frightened out of their minds, knowing they're going to die. Sorry – I just can't work up a lot of sympathy over someone like him.

BOBBY: (Pg 30) Hey, I ever show ya my toad? *(crouches down, makes toad sounds and mimes catching a fly, then jumps up laughing)*

SHAWNA: (Pg 36) *(Shakes her head)* Never take responsibility. Bad family, bad neighborhood. "I'm a victim of society" I am so sick'a that. How 'bout your victim, huh? *(long pause)*

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JOHN: (Pg 10-11) Silence for a change. *(deep breath, heavy sigh, beat)* They murdered Willie T. last night. That's why it was quiet. They never announce in on the row, but we all know when it happens. We know even before the crowd outside begins to cheer. And the silence rolls in, one cell at a time. *(rubs his face, tired)*

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BOBBY: (Pg 52) *(to audience)* They have coyotes where you grew up? . . . Nasty animals. Wipe out a whole chicken house in one night. Hate coyotes more than anything. *(howls like a*

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coyotes, then is quiet for a moment, thinking back) I know, I seen it. Just got outta' the hospital 'cause'a my hip

SAM: (Pg 42) *(to John)* Now let's talk about the obituaries. The angle of my article is that you try to . . . undemonized these men.

BOBBY: (Pg 52) So one day, my mother--I tell her I wanna go to Uncle Hew's but she--heck--she couldn't got me there if she wanted to and this man's she with, he...so I walked—*(Laughs)* Well, limped. Six miles outta town. man-oh-man it hurt.

JOHN: (Pg 42) Undemonize?

BOBBY: (Pg 52) Just wanted to get to my uncle's. I can see the lights and. . . man-oh-man I almost peed myself--cause there's this. . . monster!

SAM: (Pg 42-43) Find the positive . . . whatever. But Willie T. was an animal! Mutilating a twelve-year old boy is not the act of a human being.

BOBBY: (Pg 52) And it's floatin in the air, and I can see its eyes and--- I burst in on poor Hew shaki'n and cryin' --didn't even know I was comin,' but he hugged me and put me in the truck and drove on out there. Coyote—that's all it was – He'd shot it and stuck it up on the barbed wire. Beat on it too, while it was wounded.

SAM: (Pg 43) Sneer all you want, John. You people frighten us. We are not the bad guys just because we want to protect ourselves.

BOBBY: (Pg 52) He told me 'bout coyotes bein' evil and how it's okay ta kill 'em. That's why he stuck it up onna' fence. Let the world know -- death to predators. *(simply)* Then he told me all about the Jews. How Hitler knew they were predators. How they was usin' the n***** and mud people to turn us all into animals so they can enslave us. *(a beat, then to John)* **(Pg 49)** Watcha' gonna say 'bout me? Inna' paper. I mean, ya are gonna' write somethin' 'bout me, right. Put my name in there.

JOHN: Wish I didn't have to – What would you like.

BOBBY: Well . . . that I was a good Aryan soldier and upheld the code. **(Pg 17)** *(springing to attention)* I am Aryan!! If I am incarcerated I will remember at all times my duty as an Aryan!

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JOHN: **(Pg 49)** I'm not putting that crap in my paper – **(Pg 19)** 70% of our readership is African-American.

BOBBY: **(Pg 49-50)** Then don't write nothin' 'bout me.

JOHN: I don't have a choice here. *(pause)* Remorse, Bobby. Give me that at least, please. That's the one thing I can always fall back on – showing some remorse. Tell me you're sorry you killed 37 people.

BOBBY: **(Pg 51)** There's nothin' wrong with killin' a predator. Ol' Hew said it. Predators must be destroyed.

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SAM: **(Pg 54)** The state murdered Robert Alvin Reyburn last night. He was twenty-eight years old. Bobby was accused of a heinous crime.

JOHN: [He] never denied it. In his own unique way he was an honest man.

SAM: He did animal impressions. Forgot the words to songs. *(pause)* St. Francis once said, "Where there is charity and wisdom . . .

JOHN: . . . there is neither fear nor ignorance." Bobby Reyburn knew no charity or wisdom in his life. *(sighs sadly)* And the only person who ever loved him taught him how to hate.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Bruce Graham
ISBN: 978-0822217381
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2000

AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
CO State Qualifier

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Source information for introductory material

** Death Penalty Information Center at https://deathpenaltyinfo.org/executions/2024*

*** NBC News, "Trump wants to expand the federal death penalty…" https://www.nbcnews.com/politics/2024-election/trump-wants-expand-federal-death-penalty-setting-legal-challenges-seco-rcna178979*

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